A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR NEW OPERATORS



The Stump Grinding Playbook

Price it right. Find the jobs. Run them safely.

Works with the Pricing & Business Calculator and Templates & Scripts Pack

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FIELD NOTE

How to get the most from this kit

Work through the chapters in order the first time. If you have the companion calculator and templates, keep them open when you quote and book. Real links are in Appendix B.

START HERE

Why Stump Grinding

What the job is, who it suits, and how to use this kit.



Every tree that comes down leaves a stump behind. Most homeowners do not want to look at it, mow around it, or trip over it, and they cannot remove it themselves. That is the entire business: you show up with a machine, remove the stump below grade, clean up, and get paid for a job that often takes a few hours.

Stump grinding is attractive for beginners for a few practical reasons:

- **Low barrier to entry.** Compared with full tree service, the equipment list is short. You can start with one machine, a trailer, and a truck.
- **Fast jobs, clear scope.** Most residential stumps are a morning or afternoon job. The customer can see exactly what they are paying for.
- **Strong referral channels.** Tree removal companies, landscapers, realtors, and property managers all regularly need stumps ground and often prefer to hand the work to a specialist.
- **Repeat and add-on potential.** A satisfied customer has neighbors with stumps, and you are already on site with a machine and a truck.

It is also physical, it carries real risk if you ignore safety, and it is not a guaranteed income. Your results will depend on your market, your pricing, your equipment costs, and how consistently you market. This playbook gives you the systems, but it cannot do the work for you.

HEADS UP

A note on numbers

Every dollar figure in this playbook is an example or a starting point to help you build your own numbers. Prices, insurance costs, equipment costs, and legal requirements differ by state and by town. Verify everything locally before you rely on it. Where this book suggests a check, it is marked **VERIFY LOCALLY**.

Who this playbook is for

Beginners starting a stump grinding business or side hustle, tree service and landscaping owners adding stump grinding as a service line, and new grinder owners who have the machine but no pricing or marketing system.

How to use this playbook

Read Chapters 1 to 4 before you spend serious money, because they cover setup, equipment, safety, and pricing. Chapters 5 to 8 cover getting customers and running jobs. Chapters 9 and 10 cover systems, scaling, and a 30-day action plan.

This book works with two companion files: the **Pricing & Business Calculator** (Excel, works in Google Sheets) and the **Templates & Scripts Pack** (Word). They come with the Calculator + Templates and Full Kit versions. Wherever you see a **TOOL** reference, open the matching file. If you bought the Playbook Only version, you can still follow every chapter and use your own spreadsheet.

File	What it is	Used in
Pricing & Business Calculator (.xlsx)	Quote calculator, job profit, break-even, job tracker	Chapters 2, 4, 9
Templates & Scripts Pack (.docx)	Quote, invoice, agreement, checklists, call and text scripts, post bank, outreach messages	Chapters 3 to 8

CHAPTER 01

Set Up the Business

Name, paperwork, bank account, and the insurance questions most beginners forget.



A clean setup protects you personally and makes you look professional to customers, tree services, and property managers. None of this has to take long, but do not skip the insurance step.

1.1 Choose a name and structure

Pick a simple, local-sounding name that says what you do and where you do it. Names like "Riverside Stump Removal" work better than clever names because customers search by service and town. Before you commit, check that the name is available in your state's business registry, that a matching domain is available, and that the social handles are free.

Most small operators choose either a sole proprietorship (simplest) or a single-member LLC (adds a layer of separation between your business and personal assets). An LLC does not replace insurance, and the rules, fees, and annual requirements vary by state. A local accountant or attorney can tell you what makes sense for you. The U.S. Small Business Administration also has free guides on choosing a structure and registering.

CHECK LOCALLY

Verify this where you operate

State LLC filing fees, annual report requirements, and any local business license or registration needed to operate in your city or county. Search your state's Secretary of State website and your city or county business license page.

1.2 Basic registrations

1. **EIN.** If you form an LLC or plan to hire, get a free Employer Identification Number from the IRS website. Never pay a third party for one.
2. **State and local registrations.** Business license, sales tax registration if your state taxes services like yours, and any trade-specific rules. Requirements for stump grinding specifically are usually light, but check.
3. **Business bank account.** Open a separate checking account and use it for every business transaction. This makes taxes and bookkeeping dramatically easier.

1.3 Insurance

Insurance is not optional. Grinders throw debris, equipment can strike buried lines, and customers expect a professional to carry coverage. Many tree services and property managers will not hire you without proof of insurance.

Coverage	What it generally does	Notes
General liability	Covers third-party property damage and injury claims arising from your work	The core policy; ask whether grinding and underground damage are covered or excluded
Commercial auto	Covers your truck when used for business	Personal auto policies often exclude business use
Equipment / inland marine	Covers theft or damage to your grinder and trailer	Useful once you own expensive equipment
Workers' compensation	Covers employee injuries	Often required once you have employees; rules vary by state

When you shop for quotes, ask each agent these questions:

- Do you write policies for stump grinding or tree care specifically, or is this classed as landscaping?
- Does the policy exclude or limit damage to underground utilities, irrigation, or sewer lines?
- Can I get a certificate of insurance (COI) the same day when a customer or partner asks?
- What happens to my coverage if I add a helper?

FIELD NOTE

Worth knowing

Get at least three quotes, including one from an independent agent who works with multiple carriers. Underground damage coverage is the question most beginners forget to ask.

1.4 Bookkeeping and taxes

Track every dollar in and out from day one. At minimum, record the date, customer, amount, and payment method for income, and categorize expenses: fuel, teeth and wheels, insurance, repairs, marketing, and equipment. The **Job Tracker** tab in the calculator covers income; use a simple bookkeeping app or spreadsheet for expenses.

Self-employed operators generally owe self-employment tax in addition to income tax, and many need to make estimated tax payments during the year. Talk to a local accountant early. It is cheap compared with fixing a mess later.

HEADS UP

Not tax or legal advice

This playbook explains common practices. It is not tax, legal, or insurance advice. Talk to a licensed professional in your state before making decisions.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Separate the business bank account on day one.
- Get liability insurance before your first job, and ask about underground damage coverage.
- Check state and local licensing instead of assuming.

CHAPTER 02

Equipment Buying Guide

Match the machine to the work, inspect used gear, and know your real consumable costs.



Your grinder is the largest purchase you will make, and the wrong choice can slow you down for years. This chapter helps you match the machine to the work you actually plan to do.

2.1 Types of stump grinders

Type	Best for	Strengths	Trade-offs
Walk-behind (hand-guided)	Beginners; yards with gates and fences	Lower cost, easy to transport, fits narrow access	More physical effort; slower on large stumps
Self-propelled / tracked	Operators doing several stumps per week	Better on slopes and soft ground, less fatigue, handles bigger stumps	Higher purchase price; heavier to transport
Skid-steer or tractor attachment	Operators who already own a skid steer	Powerful, fast on large stumps	Requires the host machine; less maneuverable in tight spaces
Large trailer-mounted / commercial units	High-volume commercial work	Very fast on large or multiple stumps	Significant cost and towing requirements

Rule of thumb: match the machine to the stumps you will see most often, not the biggest one you can imagine. Most residential work is stumps in the small-to-medium range, in yards with gates, fences, and slopes. If you cannot get your machine through a typical backyard gate, you will turn down jobs.

2.2 Questions to answer before you buy

1. What gate width and access conditions are common in my market?
2. What is the largest stump diameter I expect to handle routinely?
3. What can my truck legally and safely tow, including the trailer and machine weight?
4. Can I get parts, teeth, and service locally or by quick shipping?
5. How many jobs per week do I realistically expect in my first three months?

2.3 New vs. used

A used machine can get you started for far less money, but it also carries more risk. Condition matters more than age.

Used grinder inspection checklist

- Cutter wheel: check for wobble, cracks, and bent or missing tooth pockets.
- Teeth and holders: look for worn holders, which are expensive to replace.
- Engine: cold-start it, listen for knocking, check oil, and look for smoke or leaks.
- Hydraulics (if equipped): look for leaks at hoses and fittings.
- Belts, clutch, and drive components: check for slipping or heavy wear.
- Frame and welds: look for cracks, repairs, and bent members.
- Tracks or tires: check wear and condition.
- Safety guards and shields: they should all be present and intact.
- Hour meter and service history: ask for records.
- Serial number: confirm the machine is not reported stolen and that the seller has title or proof of ownership.

> FIELD NOTE
> **Worth knowing**
> Bring someone who knows small engines or equipment, or pay a local shop to inspect before you buy. A few hundred dollars for an inspection can save thousands.

2.4 Rent first, or buy?

Renting a grinder from an equipment rental store for your first few jobs lets you test demand and learn technique without a large purchase. The downside is that rentals cost more per job and may not be available on the days you need them.

Use the **BreakEven** tab in the calculator to compare. For example, if you plan to do six jobs a week and the machine and trailer cost a combined $21,000, the tab will show how many months of profit it takes to recover that cost at your average profit per job. If the answer is longer than you are comfortable with, start with a smaller or used machine, or rent for the first month.

2.5 Truck and trailer

- Know your truck's towing capacity and the trailer plus machine weight. Do not guess.
- Use proper hitch, safety chains, and trailer brakes as required by law for your trailer's weight.

- Use ratchet straps or chains rated for the machine and secure it at multiple points.
- Check registration and any trailer inspection requirements in your state.

2.6 Teeth, wheels, and consumables

The cutting teeth are your biggest recurring cost. Sharp teeth cut faster, use less fuel, and put less strain on the machine. Dull teeth slow you down and waste money.

- Keep a spare set of teeth and the correct wrench and hardware in the truck.
- Rotate or replace teeth according to the manufacturer's guidance; do not wait until the wheel is damaged.
- Track how many jobs you get from a set so you can build the cost into your pricing. The **JobProfit** tab has a field for this.
- Buy from a reputable supplier; cheap teeth that fail early can damage the wheel.

Item to stock	Why
Spare teeth and hardware	Prevent downtime mid-job
Engine oil, filters, and hydraulic fluid (if applicable)	Routine maintenance
Fuel can and funnel	Refueling on site
Hand tools, wrenches, and grease	Quick fixes and daily maintenance
Shovel, rake, and wheelbarrow or tarp	Cleanup and moving chips
Probe bar or digging bar	Checking for rocks and metal near the stump
Marking paint or flags	Marking utility locations and hazards

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Buy for the stumps you will see most, not the biggest imaginable.
- Inspect used machines carefully, or pay a shop to do it.
- Track teeth cost per job from the start.

CHAPTER 03

Safety

PPE, work zones, and calling 811 before every single job.



A stump grinder is a spinning wheel of carbide teeth that throws wood, dirt, and sometimes rocks. Most injuries come from rushing, skipping gear, letting bystanders stand too close, or not knowing what is underground. Your first job is to go home in the same condition you left.

HEADS UP

Always follow your manual

The operator's manual for your specific machine is the authority on its safe use. Read it cover to cover before you grind your first stump. This chapter covers general good practice and does not replace the manual or any training.

3.1 Personal protective equipment (PPE)

Protection	Why	Examples
Eye and face	Chips and debris fly at high speed	Safety glasses plus a face shield or mesh visor
Hearing	Grinders are loud enough to damage hearing over time	Earmuffs or rated earplugs
Head	Overhead branches and flying debris	Hard hat if working near trees or overhead hazards
Hands	Cuts, vibration, and grip	Snug-fitting work gloves; no loose cuffs or dangling straps
Legs	Debris and accidental contact	Long, sturdy pants; consider chainsaw-style chaps if your manual or insurer recommends
Feet	Dropped tools and flying debris	Steel- or composite-toe work boots
Lungs	Fine dust and mold in old stumps	Dust mask or respirator suited to the conditions

3.2 Set up a safe work zone

- Walk the entire area before starting and note fences, windows, vehicles, play equipment, pets, and people.
- Keep bystanders, children, and pets well outside the machine's debris zone. Many manuals specify a distance of 25 feet or more; follow your manual.
- Move or cover vehicles, windows, and fragile items. Hang a tarp or use a debris shield where needed.
- Tell the customer where to stand, and ask them to keep everyone inside while you work.
- Never operate the machine if someone enters the work zone. Stop the cutter wheel first.

3.3 Utilities: call 811 before every job

Hitting a buried gas, electric, water, or communications line can injure you, cause an outage, and result in expensive repair bills. In the United States, you can dial **811** (or start at call811.com) to have public utility lines marked for free before you dig. Grinding removes soil and roots well below the surface, so treat every stump as a dig site.

1. Contact 811 (or your state's one-call center) with the exact address and work location. Do it every time, even for a stump in the same yard you did last year.
2. Wait for the legally required time before starting, which is usually a few business days. Confirm the exact waiting period and marking rules in your state.
3. Do not start until all utilities have responded and you have confirmed the marks match the ticket.
4. Keep a copy or photo of the ticket and the markings in the job file.

HEADS UP

Important: private lines are NOT marked

811 marks public utilities. It generally does not mark private lines on the customer's property: irrigation lines, invisible pet fences, landscape lighting wiring, private gas lines to grills or pools, and septic or drain lines. Ask the customer where they are, look for sprinkler heads and valve boxes, and keep grinding depth conservative near suspected lines. Your agreement should say how these are handled.

CHECK LOCALLY

Verify this where you operate

811 notification lead times, how long a ticket remains valid, and whether your state treats stump grinding as excavation. Search "[your state] 811 one call law."

3.4 Before every cut

- Inspect the stump and surrounding soil for rocks, wire, nails, and metal.
- Probe the ground around the stump with a bar and clear any stones you can reach.

- Check the machine: guards in place, teeth tight, fluids and fuel adequate.
- Confirm your footing and your escape path.
- Review the plan with any helper and agree on hand signals.

3.5 While grinding

- Engage the cutter wheel only when you are in position and the area is clear.
- Sweep side to side and lower the wheel gradually. Do not force the wheel into wood.
- Stay alert for sudden changes in sound or vibration; stop and investigate.
- Never reach into the cutting area or clear debris while the wheel is moving or has not fully stopped.
- On slopes, position yourself uphill of the machine and use caution to avoid tipping or rolling.
- Take breaks. Fatigue makes mistakes.

3.6 End of day

- Shut down, wait for the wheel to stop completely, and remove the key or disconnect as your manual directs.
- Clean debris from the machine and check teeth, belts, and fasteners.
- Secure the machine for transport or storage and do a quick walk-around.

FIELD NOTE

Daily equipment check

The Templates & Scripts Pack includes a one-page **Equipment Daily Inspection Checklist** and a **Pre-Job Site Checklist**. Print them and keep them in the truck.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Call 811 for every job and keep the ticket.
- Private lines are not marked, so ask and flag.
- Stop the wheel before anyone enters the work zone.

CHAPTER 04

Pricing and Estimating

A pricing method you can run in minutes, with a fully worked example.



Underpricing is the most common reason new stump grinders burn out. You can be busy and still lose money if you do not account for travel, fuel, teeth, insurance, and your own labor. This chapter gives you a pricing system you can run in minutes.

4.1 Common pricing methods

Method	How it works	Pros	Cons
Per inch of diameter	Price = diameter in inches x rate per inch (plus adjustments)	Simple, transparent, scales with size	Ignores access and difficulty unless you adjust
Flat price per stump	A set price based on size bands (small, medium, large)	Fast to quote	Risk of underpricing larger or harder stumps
Hourly	Hours on site x hourly rate	Matches time spent	Customers dislike open-ended pricing; rewards slowness
Hybrid (recommended)	Per-inch base, adjusted for conditions, with a minimum fee	Fair, predictable, protects margin	Needs a calculator or sheet to stay fast

This playbook recommends the hybrid approach: a per-inch base, multipliers for conditions that add time or risk, a minimum job fee, travel charges, and a multi-stump discount. The calculator builds all of this for you.

4.2 How to measure a stump

- Measure the **diameter** in inches at the widest point of the stump, at or near ground level, ideally including significant root flare where it adds to the work.
- If the stump is not round, take two measurements at right angles and average them.
- For a stump with multiple trunks, measure each trunk and price accordingly, or treat as a larger single stump.
- Note stumps that sit higher than a few inches above the ground. Extra height adds work.

- Photograph every stump with a tape measure or ruler for reference.

4.3 Adjustment factors

Not all stumps are equal. Adjust the base price for conditions that add time, wear, or risk. Starting-point multipliers are included in the calculator's Settings tab.

Factor	Why it matters	Example multiplier (starting point)
Hardwood	Dense wood dulls teeth and slows cutting	1.15 (softwood 0.90)
Heavy root flare / large surface roots	More material to remove; roots extend the work	1.25 (moderate 1.10)
Tight access	Gates, fences, or tight spaces slow setup and movement	1.15
Slope	Harder to position and operate safely	1.10 moderate, 1.20 steep
Rocks / metal risk	Increases tooth damage and risk; may warrant a waiver	1.15
Old, rotten or very wet stump	Can be easier or messier; adjust case by case	Judgment call

HEADS UP

These multipliers are placeholders

The numbers above are starting points, not market data. Call several local operators for a quote on the same stumps, compare, and set your own. Track actual time per job and adjust.

4.4 Minimum job fee and travel

Every job has fixed time: loading, driving, setup, cleanup, and paperwork. A single 8-inch stump takes nearly as much of your day as a 12-inch one. A **minimum job fee** ensures small jobs still pay for that time. Set it by calculating your cost on a small job (see Chapter 9) and adding margin.

Add a **travel charge** for distance outside a free service radius. The calculator uses a free radius (default 15 miles) and a per-mile charge beyond it. Adjust both to your market.

4.5 Multi-stump discounts

When a customer has several stumps, you save setup time and travel. Passing a portion of that saving back encourages bigger jobs. The calculator uses tiers: for example 10 percent off for two to three stumps, 15 percent for four to five, and 20 percent for six or more. Do not discount below the point where your margin disappears.

4.6 Worked example

Here is a sample job using the starting-point settings in the calculator ($4 per inch, $150 minimum, free travel within 15 miles, $3 per extra mile, 10 percent discount for two to three stumps):

Stump	Diameter	Wood	Root flare	Base ($4/in)	Adjusted
1	18 in	Hardwood (1.15)	Moderate (1.10)	$72.00	$91.08
2	14 in	Medium (1.00)	None (1.00)	$56.00	$56.00
3	24 in	Softwood (0.90)	Heavy (1.25)	$96.00	$108.00

Step	Amount
Stump subtotal	$255.08
Multi-stump discount (10%)	-$25.51
Travel (22 miles; 7 beyond free radius x $3)	+$21.00
Total before minimum	$250.57
Minimum job fee	$150.00 (not triggered)
Final quote (rounded to nearest $5)	$250

Now check the profit side. In the JobProfit tab, with two hours on site, one hour of driving, and example costs for labor, fuel, vehicle, teeth, and overhead, this job comes to about $144 in costs, leaving roughly $106 profit, or about 42 percent margin. Your own numbers will differ, which is exactly why you should plug in your real costs.

4.7 Quoting rules that protect you

- Quote in writing, with the number of stumps, grind depth, and what is included (chips, cleanup).
- State what is **not** included: backfill, seed, hauling away chips, repairs to unmarked private lines.
- Get a signed agreement or written acceptance before you start.
- Collect payment at completion, or take a deposit for larger jobs or long drives.
- If conditions change on site (hidden rocks, extra roots), tell the customer before you continue and adjust the price.

USE THE TOOL

Quote Calculator

Open the **Quote** tab, enter the stumps and conditions, and read the final quote. Keep your Settings tab updated so every quote uses your real numbers.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Use a per-inch base, adjust for conditions, and keep a minimum fee.
- Price from your own costs, not from a stranger's number.
- Quote in writing with scope and exclusions.

CHAPTER 05

Getting Your First Customers

Google, partners, neighborhoods, and reviews: where the first jobs come from.



The best grinder in the world earns nothing without work. Your first customers will come from a handful of channels, and you can use most of them with little or no ad spend. Pick two or three to start and run them consistently.

5.1 Google Business Profile (your most important free tool)

When someone searches "stump grinding near me," the businesses in the local map results get most of the calls. A complete Google Business Profile is your best free lead source.

1. Create or claim your profile at business.google.com. Verify it using the method Google offers.
2. Choose the most specific primary category available that matches your work (such as a stump grinding or tree service category) and add secondary categories if they fit. Check the category list in the setup menu.
3. Set your service area by city or radius. If you work from home and do not serve customers at your address, hide your address as the platform allows.
4. Add a clear business description, phone number, hours, and a website or booking link.
5. List your services, such as stump grinding, root grinding, and multi-stump discounts.
6. Upload real photos: before and after shots, the machine, and your truck. Add new ones every few weeks.
7. Ask every happy customer for a review (see 5.7).

CHECK LOCALLY

Verify this where you operate

Google changes categories, verification rules, and features. Follow current prompts in your dashboard and review Google's policies before posting. Do not use a fake address or fake reviews.

5.2 Simple local SEO

- Build a one-page website with your services, service area, photos, a phone number, and a quote request form.
- Add a separate short page for each major town you serve, with real photos and details from jobs in that town.
- Keep your business name, address (if public), and phone number identical everywhere online.
- Get listed on a few trusted directories and your local chamber of commerce if there is one.

5.3 Partnerships (often your fastest source of jobs)

Tree removal companies often prefer to subcontract stump work, and landscapers, realtors, and property managers regularly need stumps removed. A few reliable partners can fill your calendar.

Partner	Why they send work	How to approach
Tree removal companies	They remove trees but may not own a grinder or want the extra job	Offer a referral fee or wholesale rate; show insurance and reliability
Landscapers and lawn crews	Stumps block projects and mowing	Offer quick turnaround and clean results
Realtors and home stagers	Stumps hurt curb appeal before a sale	Offer fast scheduling and a before and after photo
Property managers and HOAs	They manage many properties and need a vendor	Provide a COI and a simple recurring-service offer
Fence, deck, and pool contractors	Stumps block new installations	Offer pre-project stump removal

Use the **Outreach Messages** in the Templates & Scripts Pack. Send ten messages a week, follow up once, and visit the best prospects in person with a business card and your COI.

5.4 Door hangers and neighborhood marketing

- After each job, leave a short door hanger or flyer at the neighbors' doors: "We just removed a stump at [address]. Ask us about neighborhood pricing."
- Do not put flyers inside mailboxes. U.S. federal law reserves mailboxes for postal items, so use door handles or hangers.
- Check your city or HOA rules before distributing materials.
- Park your branded truck where it is visible, with permission and safely.

5.5 Facebook, Nextdoor, and community groups

Local community groups are full of people asking for tree and stump help. Participate genuinely: answer questions, share before and after photos, and respond to requests. Read each group's rules first. Many ban direct advertising outside designated threads, and spammy posting gets you removed.

- Create a Facebook business page and a Nextdoor business page.
- Post a job photo and a short story once or twice a week.
- Respond to requests within minutes. Speed wins.
- Use the **Post Bank** in the Templates & Scripts Pack for ready-to-edit posts.

5.6 Optional: short-form video

Short videos of grinding, before and after results, and quick tips can build local trust and attract leads. A few filmed jobs a week can feed a local audience, especially when you geotag the town and mention your service area. Never film in a way that distracts from safety, and get the customer's permission before posting their property.

5.7 Reviews: the multiplier

- Ask for a review while the customer is still delighted, right after the job.
- Send a short text with a direct link to your Google review page.
- Reply to every review, positive or negative, politely and professionally.
- Do not offer discounts, gifts, or payment in exchange for reviews. Google's policies prohibit incentivized reviews.

FIELD NOTE

Goal for your first 90 days

Reach 10 genuine reviews, two active referral partners, and a completed Google Business Profile with at least 20 photos.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Finish your Google Business Profile before anything fancy.
- A few steady partners can outperform any ad.
- Never pay for or trade rewards for reviews.

CHAPTER 06

Quoting and Selling

From first call to signed quote, including what to say when they push back.



Most stump grinding customers are not shopping for the cheapest option. They want someone who answers quickly, shows up, explains the process clearly, and leaves their yard clean. Your sales process should make that obvious.

6.1 The first contact

Speed matters. Aim to answer every call, text, or form within 15 minutes during business hours. If you cannot answer, use a voicemail greeting that promises a callback time and send an automatic text.

On the first call or message, collect:

- Name, address, and best contact number
- Number of stumps and approximate diameter of each
- Type of tree if known, and how long ago it was cut
- Access: gates, fences, and distance from the street
- Any irrigation, pet fences, lights, or buried lines they know about
- Photos of each stump with something for scale, such as a tape measure or shoe

USE THE TOOL

Phone and Text Scripts

The Templates & Scripts Pack includes a first-call script, a photo-request text, a quote-follow-up text, and responses to common objections.

6.2 Quoting from photos

A photo quote lets you respond in minutes without driving out. State clearly that the quote is based on the photos and may change if conditions on site differ.

1. Ask for two photos per stump: one wide shot showing access, one close-up with a tape measure.

2. Estimate diameter from the photos, run the calculator, and send a clear quote.
3. Include what is covered, what is not, and a window for scheduling.
4. Confirm 811 timing and ask about private lines.

6.3 The on-site estimate

For larger jobs or hard-to-judge stumps, a quick on-site visit builds trust and prevents surprises. Treat it as a short professional consultation rather than a free-for-all.

1. Walk the property with the customer and note every stump.
2. Measure diameters and note roots, slope, and obstacles.
3. Ask where they want the chips, whether they want the hole filled, and whether they want seed or sod.
4. Explain the process: grinding depth, the chip pile, and what the area will look like afterward.
5. Give the quote on the spot or within a few hours, in writing.

6.4 Explaining what the customer gets

Many customers are surprised by the mound of chips and the shallow depression where the stump was. Set expectations upfront:

- Grinding removes the stump to roughly six to twelve inches below ground level, depending on the agreement. This is usually enough for lawn restoration or planting a shrub.
- The result is a pile of wood chips and soil. You can leave it, spread it, or haul it away depending on the quote.
- Large roots may remain below the surface unless you agree to grind them out. Be specific about root grinding.
- If the customer plans to replant a tree in the same location, discuss grinding deeper or choosing a different spot.

6.5 Handling objections

Objection	Response
"That's more than I expected."	Explain what the price includes: insurance, utility locate process, cleanup, and travel. Offer a discount for multiple stumps, or reduce scope (leave chips, skip backfill) if appropriate.
"My neighbor's guy charges less."	"That's possible. I price by stump size, and I carry full insurance and call 811 before every job. If another quote includes the same scope and cleanup, I'm happy to look at what they offered."
"I'll think about it."	"Of course. I can hold this price for 14 days. Would it help if I sent the quote in writing so you can compare?" Follow up in 2 days.
"Can you do it for cash and no paperwork?"	Stay professional. Pay and paperwork protect both of you. "I give every customer a written quote and invoice; it protects us both."
"Can you grind it deeper for free?"	Offer it as an add-on at a clear price, especially for replanting or construction.

6.6 Closing the job

- Offer two or three clear scheduling options.
- Ask for written acceptance via the quote template or a reply text or email.
- Confirm 811 timing, access, and any customer prep, such as moving vehicles and clearing the area.
- Send a confirmation message the day before.

USE THE TOOL

Quote, Agreement, and Invoice

Use the **Quote Template**, **Service Agreement**, and **Invoice Template** in the Templates & Scripts Pack. Edit your business details once and reuse them.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Answer fast. Speed wins most local jobs.
- Photo quotes save drives, but state they can change.
- Set expectations on chips, depth, and roots up front.

CHAPTER 07

Doing the Job

A repeatable routine from arrival to final walkthrough.



A smooth job is a repeatable routine. Follow the same steps every time and your results will be consistent, your customers will notice, and your risk will drop.

7.1 Arrival and site walk

1. Arrive within the agreed window. If you are running late, text before you are late.
2. Introduce yourself and walk the site with the customer. Confirm the stumps, the scope, and the quote.
3. Confirm 811 markings are present and match your ticket.
4. Ask again about irrigation, pet fences, lights, and other private lines. Mark them with flags.
5. Take "before" photos of every stump and the surrounding area.
6. Have the customer sign the agreement or confirm acceptance if you have not already.

7.2 Prepare the stump

- Cut the stump as low as practical if the tree service left it high. A lower start means less grinding.
- Remove rocks, wire, nails, or debris around the stump. Hosing off dirt at the base often reveals hidden stones.
- Probe around the stump with a bar to detect rocks and buried objects.
- Remove or protect nearby items, such as garden beds, statues, and vehicles.

7.3 Grinding technique

Technique makes the job faster, safer, and easier on your machine. The details vary by machine, so follow your manual, but these principles apply broadly:

1. **Position yourself** where you can control the machine and see the cutter wheel and the stump.
2. **Start from one side** of the stump, with the wheel just above the surface.

3. **Sweep side to side** in a controlled arc. Let the teeth cut; do not force the wheel.
4. **Lower the wheel gradually** after each pass, taking shallow bites rather than deep ones.
5. **Work across the full width** of the stump, then lower and repeat until you reach the agreed depth.
6. **Grind the root flare** and any exposed surface roots to the agreed extent.
7. **Stop and reassess** if you hear metal, hit a rock, or see sparks. Do not continue blindly.

FIELD NOTE

Depth guideline

Many operators grind about six to twelve inches below the surrounding grade for lawn restoration. Grind deeper if the customer plans to plant a tree or build in the same spot. Always write the agreed depth in the quote.

7.4 Dealing with problems

Problem	What to do
Hidden rocks	Stop, remove if possible, or grind around. Inform the customer if it affects scope or price.
Metal (nails, wire, fence remnants)	Stop immediately. Remove what you can. Metal can seriously damage teeth and wheel.
Very large or numerous roots	Explain the added work and offer to grind roots at an extra charge, or leave them if the customer agrees.
Unmarked private line damage	Stop work, shut off the machine, keep everyone safe, and follow your agreement and insurance procedures. Document everything with photos.
Customer changes mind mid-job	Pause, restate the original scope, and agree on any changes in writing or by text before continuing.
Machine breakdown	Call the customer, reschedule, and avoid improvising dangerous fixes on site.

7.5 Cleanup

Cleanup is where good operators win referrals. Customers remember how the yard looked when you left more than they remember how long the grinding took.

- Rake and shovel chips into a tidy pile, spread them thinly, or load them into your truck, per the agreement.
- Fill the hole with chips and soil if included, and tamp lightly. Leave a slight mound to allow for settling.
- Sweep or blow debris off driveways, sidewalks, and patios.
- Remove all flags and equipment.

- Check that fences, gates, and hardscape are clean and undamaged.

7.6 Final walkthrough and payment

1. Walk the site with the customer and confirm the work matches the agreement.
2. Take "after" photos.
3. Present the invoice and collect payment as agreed.
4. Ask for a review while they are happy, using a text with a direct link.
5. Give them care tips: the area will settle, grass will need seed or sod, and wood chips can be used as mulch or composted away from the house.

USE THE TOOL

Job-Day Checklist

The **Pre-Job Site Checklist** and **Post-Job Walkthrough** in the Templates & Scripts Pack keep you consistent from job to job.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Same routine every time: site walk, prep, grind, clean, walkthrough.
- Stop when you hit metal or unexpected conditions.
- Great cleanup is the cheapest marketing you have.

CHAPTER 08

Upsells and Repeat Business

Add-ons, referrals, and seasonal planning that raise your average job.



Once you are on site with a machine and a truck, small add-ons can raise your average ticket without much extra effort. Only offer what you can deliver well, and always quote it clearly.

8.1 Add-ons customers actually want

Add-on	Idea	Notes
Extra stumps	"Any other stumps while I'm here?" Offer a multi-stump rate	Best margin: no extra travel
Haul-away of chips	Charge for loading and disposal	Account for disposal cost and time
Chip pile left as mulch	Free or low-cost; saves your disposal time	Customers often like free mulch
Topsoil and grass seed	Fill the hole, add seed and starter fertilizer	Offer a finished-lawn price
Sod patch	Higher price for instant results	Only if you can source it locally
Root grinding	Grind visible surface roots	Quote by root diameter or length
Deeper grind for replanting	Grind below standard depth	Priced as a premium

8.2 How to offer an upsell

Upsell by making the customer's life easier, not by pushing. A simple way: "Most people want the hole filled and seeded so the lawn grows back. I can do that for [price] while I'm here. Do you want me to include it?"

8.3 Referrals and repeat work

- Ask every satisfied customer: "Do you know a neighbor or friend with stumps?" Leave a few business cards.
- Thank referrals with a clear, simple reward you can afford, such as a discount on their next job. Check that your reward does not violate review-platform rules (do not tie rewards to reviews).
- Keep a customer list and message past customers once or twice a year. Spring and fall are natural times.

- Stay in touch with partners. A quick text after each partner referral, with before and after photos, builds trust.

8.4 Seasonal planning

- Spring and early fall are often busy for outdoor work in many regions. Winter may be slow in cold climates; use the downtime for maintenance, marketing, and partner outreach.
- After storms, tree services get busy and stumps pile up. Reach out to partners before storm season and let them know you have capacity.
- Frozen or very wet ground can affect access and cleanup. Plan scheduling accordingly.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- More stumps on the same visit is the best-margin add-on.
- Ask for referrals while the customer is happy.
- Plan around your region's busy and slow seasons.

CHAPTER 09

Systems and Scaling

The numbers to watch, simple scheduling, and when to hire.



Systems let you handle more jobs without more chaos. Start simple and add tools only when they solve a real problem.

9.1 Know your numbers

Four numbers tell you almost everything about your business health:

Metric	How to calculate	Why it matters
Profit per job	Revenue minus all costs including your labor	Shows whether pricing works
Revenue per hour (including drive)	Job revenue divided by total hours	Compares jobs and tells you which to avoid
Close rate	Jobs completed divided by leads or quotes	Shows whether your sales process works
Cost per lead	Marketing spend divided by leads	Shows which channels deserve more effort

The **JobProfit** and **Tracker** tabs calculate these for you. Review them weekly for the first three months.

9.2 Scheduling and routing

- Group jobs by neighborhood to reduce drive time and fuel.
- Book jobs in half-day blocks and leave buffer for surprises.
- Confirm every job the day before by text.
- Use a shared calendar and keep 811 ticket dates in the event notes.
- Do not stack too many jobs in one day. One equipment problem should not ruin the day.

9.3 Simple customer management

A spreadsheet is enough to start. As volume grows, a free or low-cost CRM or field service app can help with quotes, invoicing, reminders, and payment links. Choose one that handles estimates, invoices, scheduling, and customer messaging.

- Save every customer's contact info, address, job notes, and photos.
- Record where each lead came from so you know which marketing works.
- Set reminders to follow up on unanswered quotes after 2 and 7 days.
- Tag past customers so you can message them seasonally.

9.4 When to hire help

A helper can speed up cleanup, handle chips, and improve safety by providing a second set of eyes. Consider hiring when you consistently have more jobs than you can handle, or when cleanup is eating your day.

- Decide whether the person will be an employee or an independent contractor. Classification rules are legal and tax matters and vary by state; get professional advice before you decide.
- Confirm workers' compensation requirements in your state and update your insurance.
- Train every helper on safety rules, PPE, and the work-zone procedures in this book before they touch equipment.
- Start with cleanup and support tasks; do not let a new person operate the grinder until you have trained and watched them.

9.5 Adding a second machine or a new service

- Add a second machine only when you are consistently booked and turning away work.
- Consider a larger grinder if large stumps are a regular source of jobs, or a smaller one for tight yards.
- Natural add-ons include tree removal, brush clearing, land clearing, mulch delivery, and lawn restoration. Each brings new insurance, equipment, and training requirements.
- Do not expand until your core pricing and systems are solid.

9.6 Pricing check-ups

Review your pricing every quarter. Compare actual hours and costs with your quotes, track tooth wear, and adjust. Raise prices when you are booked more than a week or two out; that is a sign the market will bear it.

USE THE TOOL

Break-Even and Tracker

Use the **BreakEven** tab before big purchases and the **Tracker** tab every week.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Review profit per job, revenue per hour, and close rate weekly.
- Group jobs by neighborhood.
- Get professional advice before hiring.

CHAPTER 10

Your 30-Day Action Plan

Week by week, from paperwork to your first paid jobs.



This plan gets you from zero to your first paying jobs. Adjust the sequence to your situation, but keep moving. A rough launch beats a perfect plan.

Week 1: Foundation

1. Choose your business name and check availability.
2. Register your business, get an EIN if needed, and open a business bank account.
3. Get at least three insurance quotes and buy general liability coverage.
4. Decide on equipment: rent, buy used, or buy new. Run the numbers in the BreakEven tab.
5. Read your machine's manual cover to cover and arrange basic training if available.
6. Collect your PPE and safety gear.

Week 2: Marketing basics and pricing

1. Set your prices in the calculator's Settings tab after calling several local operators.
2. Create your Google Business Profile and complete every field.
3. Build a simple one-page website and add a quote request form.

4. Customize your Quote, Agreement, and Invoice templates with your business information.
5. Make business cards, a door hanger, and a magnet or truck sign if budget allows.
6. Take sample before and after photos, even from practice jobs on friends' or family's stumps (with permission).

Week 3: Outreach and first jobs

1. Send your first 30 partner outreach messages to tree services, landscapers, realtors, and property managers.
2. Post in local Facebook groups and Nextdoor, following each group's rules.
3. Answer every lead within 15 minutes.
4. Quote your first jobs using the calculator and templates.
5. Complete your first jobs with the pre-job checklist, 811 ticket, and post-job walkthrough.
6. Ask every customer for a review and referral.

Week 4: Refine and grow

1. Log every job in the Tracker and calculate profit per job and revenue per hour.
2. Compare your actual time and costs with your quotes and adjust pricing.
3. Follow up with every unanswered quote and every partner.
4. Set up a simple weekly routine: marketing, quotes, jobs, bookkeeping, maintenance.
5. Set goals for the next 60 days: reviews, partners, jobs per week, and profit per job.

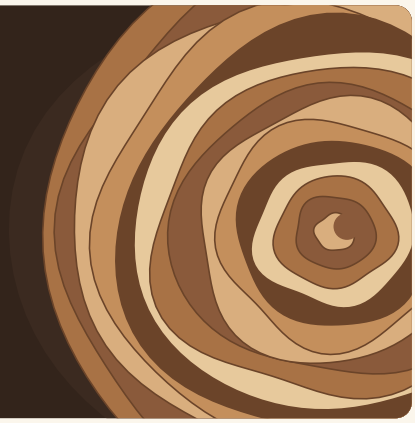
30-day checklist

Done?	Task
[ ]	Business name, registration, EIN, bank account
[ ]	General liability (and auto, as needed) insurance in place
[ ]	Equipment decided, inspected, and transport secured
[ ]	PPE purchased; manual read; safety routine written
[ ]	Prices set in the calculator from local research
[ ]	Google Business Profile live with photos
[ ]	Templates customized (quote, agreement, invoice)
[ ]	30 partner outreach messages sent
[ ]	First 3 jobs completed and logged
[ ]	First 3 reviews collected

APPENDIX A

Quick Reference

Cheat sheet, review text, and glossary.



Pre-job essentials

- 811 ticket confirmed and marks match
- Private lines discussed and flagged
- Written quote and signed agreement
- PPE, spare teeth, tools, and probe bar loaded
- Customer informed about work zone and chip handling

Pricing formula (hybrid)

Final quote = [Sum of (diameter x rate per inch x wood x flare)] x access x slope x rocks, less multi-stump discount, plus travel charge, never below the minimum fee, rounded to your chosen increment.

Review request text

"Thanks again for choosing [Business Name]. If you have a minute, a quick Google review helps a lot: [link]. Thank you!"

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Cutter wheel	The spinning wheel with carbide teeth that grinds the stump
Grade	The level of the surrounding ground
Root flare	The widening at the base of the trunk where roots begin
811	The U.S. one-call number used to request marking of public underground utilities
COI	Certificate of insurance, proof of coverage for customers and partners
Multiplier	A factor applied to a base price for harder conditions
Minimum job fee	The lowest price you will accept for any job
Close rate	The percent of leads or quotes that become paid jobs

APPENDIX B

Resources and Links

Real, free links to get started.



These are real, free starting points. Websites change, so if a page has moved, search the site name.

Resource	What it is for	Link
811 (Call Before You Dig)	Start a utility locate request and find your state's one-call rules	call811.com
IRS: Apply for an EIN	Get your free Employer Identification Number	irs.gov (EIN application)
U.S. Small Business Administration	Free guides on structure, licenses, and funding	sba.gov
Google Business Profile	Your free local listing for maps and search	business.google.com
OSHA	Workplace safety standards and guidance	osha.gov

FIELD NOTE

Your companion files

Open the **Pricing & Business Calculator** to quote jobs and track profit, and the **Templates & Scripts Pack** for quotes, agreements, checklists, and messages. Both come with the Full Kit and the Calculator + Templates versions.

APPENDIX C

Final Notes and Disclaimers

Read this before you rely on anything in the book.



This playbook is educational and provides general information for people starting or growing a stump grinding business. It is not legal, tax, insurance, financial, or safety advice, and it does not guarantee any income or result. Laws, licensing, insurance requirements, utility-locate rules, and market prices vary by location and change over time. Always verify local requirements, follow your equipment manufacturer's instructions, and consult qualified professionals. Using any templates, scripts, or calculators is at your own risk; have a local attorney review agreements before relying on them.

Good luck, work safely, and price like a professional.